

Episode 197: *Mawaru Penguindrum* Colour Design Notes – Part 22

"Hot and cold until the equinox" - truly the old people said good things. The lingering summer heat has completely ended, and it's suddenly autumn these days. Summer has ended! For those lamenting this, no no you're wrong - autumn has finally begun!

There are two ways to view everything, and which way you view it often becomes quite a key point. It's the same at anime production sites. Not just in terms of creating screens and performances, but also schedule-wise - changing your perspective often expands possibilities.

You see, it's not "only one month left!" but "still one month available!" This is it!

...Yes, I'll do my best (sob).

Now then.

Episode 19: My Destined Person Storyboard & Direction/Goto Keiji, Colour Direction/Akimoto Yuki

A sukiyaki party at the Takakura house surrounding Himari who finally managed to be discharged from the hospital. Meanwhile, Tabuki leaves Yuri and goes missing. While the storm seemed to have passed for now, secret meetings between the missing parents and Kanba, suspicious Mario, anxiety elements gradually grow larger. At such a Takakura house, Masako appears before Himari. Telling Himari that she herself is Takakura Kanba's sister, she assaults to force open Himari's sealed memory doors. Thus Himari begins remembering her true origins... Such was Episode 19.

Finally the story begins moving toward the finale. Within the series, it's an episode bridging before the next big wave. In terms of colour design, it was quietly and matter-of-factly assembled. But Episode 19's ending has dynamic scenes that surprised everyone (laugh), creating a flow that suggests the premonition "Is it finally coming!?"

First, the opening scene shock. Kanba, who had been saying he didn't know his parents' whereabouts throughout all episodes, casually meets with his parents (laugh). And the location of that secret meeting was a ramen shop called "Ogikubo's Taste: Rina-chan."

"Isn't there a good ramen shop somewhere?" asked Director Ikuhara. There was a prior plan for a scene of sitting side by side at a counter, so we started by searching for a ramen shop that would suit that performance. While Ogikubo has many ramen shops with counters as their main feature, most shops have narrow frontages and long depths. That makes it difficult to compose the camera angles and performances we wanted. Plus it tends to create unwanted oppressive feelings on screen above all. So we naturally narrowed it down to a certain ramen shop. Or actually, that shop immediately came to mind for several of us from the start. A structure facing the street where the counter's back side is almost entirely glass doors you can enter and exit through. And that fascinating counter bend (laugh).

Production assistant Kagaya casually went to take photos, casually talked to the owner, and casually received consent (?) (laugh). And what was completed was "Ogikubo's Taste: Rina-chan."

But you know, we few who understood future episodes including the director were somewhat anxious. "Ahhhh, dangerous! A body will be found in this shop later. Is this okay? We used it exactly as-is (sweat)"

Yuri in the rain at the apartment. This scene aimed for the coldness of the subtle relationship balance between two people being broken. Grey monotone colour tone of the interior with lighting turned off due to rain outside the window. The cut-and-sew that Yuri is wearing is also grey. In such monotone, the red of curtains and sofa further enhances the feeling of emptiness. The interspersed flashback scene - the coffee shop scene with Tabuki - is clearly contrasting with soft warm interior lighting even in the same rain. With this flashback inserted, you can feel even more cold air.

For the Takakura house sukiyaki party scene, it was above all "meat is life!" First, good animation. Then colour. Furthermore, tremendous support from special effects! Incidentally, for days like this, I go eat expensive meat sukiyaki once a year! (Half serious (laugh))

The presents from #3 to Penguins #1 and #2 were otter and seahorse yarn costumes. Well, otter was immediately decided as brown! But the problem was seahorse. Starting with the simple question "What colour exactly is a seahorse?" I did tonnes of internet image searches and looked at considerable reference material, but hmm, honestly realistic colours were too plain and you couldn't tell what it was at all (laugh). Then let's make it a completely different colour! So I tried eye-catching purple. I mean, if you can't tell what it is anyway, it's better to be cute as a set with the otter, right? Such was the birth of the purple seahorse.

And the shocking ending. What's shocking? Why that sphere? (laugh) Plus transported by truck (laugh).

That sphere was entirely made in 3D. I selected the texture material feeling. Smooth, heavy, densely solid feeling. Actually, placing this kind of 3D object on 2D screens is difficult. What's most concerning is ground contact feeling. I gave considerable rejections to what the 3D team first provided, working on sphere bottom shadow texture, ground contact shadow size and gradual density, and so on - within time and budget balance we had it built up to a level where it might be okay. Simple shapes doing simple movements actually make various rough spots stand out easily, so it's really difficult. Learning daily through various hands-on experience. I really think so.

Even so, Himari - that giant ventilation fan facing the neighbouring small park, she must have seen it every day, but never remembered it until now? (laugh)

Oh yes, the key to Yuri's apartment actually uses my apartment key as a model. The key initially prepared as reference was an ordinary cylinder lock key, and I said "Such a

pickable key couldn't exist in this kind of apartment!" so we used my key... Ah, I don't live in such a luxury apartment mansion! Just to be clear (laugh).

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